Elite College Admissions 2026: Deep Research for HS Classes of 2028 and 2030

Research conducted May 3, 2026; revised May 3, 2026 to correct factual errors, tighten sourcing, fix the cohort framing, and add family-portfolio strategy.

Family situation (target audience for this note):

Daughter	HS class	Currently	Applies (ED)	Enters college	Decisions land
A	2028	end of 10th grade	Nov 2027	Fall 2028	Mar 2028
B	2030	end of 8th grade	Nov 2029	Fall 2030	Mar 2030

Two daughters, two years apart, ~2 academic years of in-college overlap (fall 2030 – spring 2032). California residents, San Diego / Bishop area, both STEM-leaning. **The previous version of this note conflated them into a single cohort; that was wrong and produced misleading advice. This revision splits the playbooks.**

TL;DR — The Verdict

The post-pandemic test-optional era is **dead at the top**. The post-affirmative-action era is **two cycles in and still settling**. The post-ChatGPT era is **just beginning**, and admissions is moving toward AI-mediated screening (Caltech's voice-interview pilot is the leading indicator). California's 2024 ban on legacy at private colleges is the first major redistributive act of the new regime. The federal sibling-discount in financial aid was eliminated in 2024–25 and is not coming back.

The four highest-leverage decisions you can still influence, applied to your two daughters:

1. **Real, verifiable test scores** for both — 1530+ SAT or 35+ ACT. Six of eight Ivies, MIT, Caltech, Stanford, and Duke now require it. *(Daughter A: target spring 2027. Daughter B: not yet — premature prep depreciates.)*
2. **Build one verifiable spike per daughter, with external validation.** *(Daughter A: identify by summer 2026, artifact by Dec 2026. Daughter B: foundations now — math acceleration, reading volume, breadth — actual spike-building belongs in 10th–11th grade.)*
3. **Use ED deliberately** at one school where ED gives ~1.5–3× the RD rate, where the daughter is at or above middle-50 of admits, and where the family has already run the **net price calculator** and modeled the financial overlap years. ED has a financial-aid escape clause; "sight-unseen" is a misframing.
4. **Treat essays as the only signal you fully control** — write authentic teenager prose. Polished/generic essays were always weak; AI prose tends to amplify those weaknesses.

What is genuinely new in this revision (and was missing before):

- **Financial-aid expansion at top privates** (HYPSM-tier free tuition <$200K–$250K) is now the dominant variable for middle-/upper-middle-income California families. Often makes elite privates cheaper than UCs.
- **Federal sibling discount eliminated in FAFSA SAI** — but CSS Profile schools quietly compensate institutionally. Has direct dollar implications for your overlap years.
- **Family-portfolio strategy** — coordinated targets, complementary spikes, non-overlapping recommenders, shared counselor capital.
- **Two separate playbooks** below (Part VI for Daughter A, Part VII for Daughter B). Don't apply the older daughter's playbook to the younger one.

Part I: The Macro Reset (2023–2026) — Five Structural Shifts

1. Standardized testing came back at the top — fast and decisively

Required for the 2026–2027 cycle (Class of 2030): Harvard, Yale, Dartmouth, Brown, Cornell, Penn, MIT, Caltech, Stanford, Duke, Georgetown.

Princeton: test-optional through 2026–27, required from 2027–28. **Columbia:** permanent test-optional (only Ivy with permanent policy). **Yale:** "test-flexible" — accepts SAT, ACT, **AP, or IB**:

> "While the policy will still require students to submit test scores for admissions, students can satisfy the requirement by submitting scores from any of four options: SAT, ACT, AP, or IB exams." — Yale admissions

Stanford: *"Beginning with the 2025–2026 application cycle, Stanford will reinstate its standardized testing requirement. ACT or SAT scores will be required for first-year and transfer students submitting applications for the Fall 2026 entry term."*

Harvard's official rationale (Dean Hopi Hoekstra, April 11, 2024, *Harvard Gazette*):

> "Standardized tests are a means for all students, regardless of their background and life experience, to provide information that is predictive of success in college and beyond. More information, especially such strongly predictive information, is valuable for identifying talent from across the socioeconomic range."

> "When students have the option of not submitting their test scores, they may choose to withhold information that, when interpreted by the admissions committee in the context of the local norms of their school, could have potentially helped their application."

> "Fundamentally, we know that talent is universal, but opportunity is not."

Critical reading: The "equity" framing is real but secondary. The deeper subtext: in a world where GPAs are inflated to 4.0+ at every elite high school and AI can write essays, **a test score is the last hard, hard-to-fake number left in the application**. That's why it returned.

Operational implication: Below the 25th percentile of admitted students at your target schools, you're effectively out. Above the 75th, you're merely eligible for further review.

Score floors at top targets (admitted middle 50%, recent classes):

- **MIT:** SAT ~1540–1580 / ACT 35–36
- **Stanford / Caltech / Harvard / Princeton / Yale:** SAT 1500–1580 / ACT 34–36
- **UCLA / Berkeley: test-blind today** (UC system does not look at scores at all — but actively under reconsideration; see Part V on "what may shift")

2. Race-conscious admissions ended; the demographic data is in

The ruling, Roberts majority, June 29, 2023 (SFFA v. Harvard):

> “Harvard’s and UNC’s admissions programs violate the Equal Protection Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment.”

The “essay loophole” — same opinion:

> “Nothing in this opinion should be construed as prohibiting universities from considering an applicant’s discussion of how race affected his or her life, be it through discrimination, inspiration, or otherwise.”

But Roberts immediately closed it:

> “Despite the dissent’s assertion to the contrary, universities may not simply establish through application essays or other means the regime we hold unlawful today.”

Two-cycle data from elite institutions (Brookings, Harvard Crimson, MIT News):

Institution	Pre-SFFA Black %	Class of 2028	Class of 2029
Harvard	~18%	14%	11.5%
Princeton	~9%	8.9%	5%
Amherst	11%	7%	6%
MIT	~13%	5%	(variable)
Caltech	~5%	5%	1.6%

> “Out of 29 elite institutions that reported fall 2025 enrollment data, only two still maintain Black enrollment of at least 10%, while 11 reported levels of 5% or lower.” — Brookings, 2025

MIT’s own 2024 summary:

> “Compared to the Class of 2027, MIT’s Class of 2028 experienced a decrease in the percentage of Black students, dropping from 15 percent to 5 percent. The share of Hispanic students also fell, from 16 percent to 11 percent…. Asian American enrollment increased significantly, rising from 40 percent to 47 percent.”

Honest implication for Asian-American applicants: The structural penalty has measurably eased at STEM-heavy elites (MIT, Caltech). At Harvard, Yale, Princeton, the change is **modest and uneven** — not the “material rise” the original version of this note claimed.

The 2009 Espenshade & Radford figure (*No Longer Separate, Not Yet Equal*) often quoted as “Asian applicants need 140 SAT points more than whites”:

> “African American applicants receive an advantage equivalent to 310 SAT points and Asian Americans are penalized the equivalent of 140 SAT points.” — Espenshade & Radford, Table 3.5 (Fall 1997 data)

Important caveats (UCLA Law Review, West-Faulcon 2019, citing the authors’ own footnote): the data is from **Fall 1997 admissions**, and the SAT-point conversion methodology is acknowledged by the authors themselves to **inflate** racial differences. The more current and methodologically defensible estimate is the **NBER follow-up** (Arcidiacono et al., Working Paper 27068): Asian admit rates would rise about 1 percentage point (~19% relative increase) under race-blind treatment at Harvard.

The Stanley Zhong v. Cornell suit (filed March 2025), and his earlier UC litigation, signal that legal pressure is now on the *holistic-review* layer itself, not just race-conscious admissions.

Essay strategy: Roberts technically allows discussion of race tied to "a quality of character or unique ability." In practice, top admissions offices have been instructed by general counsel to evaluate this very narrowly. **Do not write a "race essay" unless race is genuinely central to the applicant's intellectual trajectory.** It is not the wedge it was.

3. California killed legacy and donor preferences (AB 1780)

> "California Bans Legacy Admissions: AB 1780, signed September 30, 2024, prohibits California private colleges and universities from giving admissions preference to applicants who are related to donors or alumni. The law takes effect on September 1, 2025." — NBC News, ABC News, Sep–Oct 2024

> "The new law will have the most profound impact on a handful of private universities in California, such as Stanford, USC, Santa Clara, Pepperdine, Claremont McKenna, and Harvey Mudd. In 2022, legacy admissions accounted for about 14 percent of Stanford and USC's enrollment." — Crimson Education, 2024

Newsom: *"In California, everyone should be able to get ahead through merit, skill, and hard work. The California Dream shouldn't be accessible to just a lucky few."*

National wave: California is the fifth state with such a ban, second to apply it to private institutions. Johns Hopkins, Amherst, Wesleyan, MIT, and U Chicago dropped legacy preferences before being legally compelled. Maryland, Virginia, Illinois, and Colorado have varying-scope bans.

Important caveat (correcting earlier framing): AB 1780 currently has **no enforcement penalty** — it requires reporting only. Stanford had announced it was ending legacy preference anyway. So the *practical* effect is real but evolving; don't read it as an immediate admissions windfall. These schools won't shrink classes — they'll redistribute via athletes, first-gen, geographic diversity, and "institutional priorities."

4. Generative AI broke the essay layer

Common App's policy (2025–2026 cycle):

> "The Common App has a very clear and stringent policy on the use of AI. It actually considers the use of generative AI in the writing of college essays as a form of plagiarism, which it categorizes as part of its Fraud Policy."

UC Statement of Integrity:

> "Students may receive advice on content and editing, including the use of generative artificial intelligence software to assist with readability, but content and final written text must be their own."

Caltech (most explicit):

> "Applicants may use AI to do research, pose brainstorming questions, or check grammar and spelling. Applicants may not use AI to outline the essay, draft text, or translate the essay from another language."

Northwestern: *"Unauthorized use of ChatGPT or other Generative AI tools is considered cheating and/or plagiarism."*
Duke — opposite direction: explicitly permits AI, eliminated numerical essay scoring in 2024, added an *optional AI-themed* supplement for 2025–2026.

Important calibration (correcting earlier overconfidence): No top-10 school has publicly admitted to using AI detection software at scale; the false-positive rate is unacceptable. Detection happens via trained human readers' pattern-matching. There is **no published empirical evidence** that human readers reliably detect AI prose at scale — the "AI prose loses" claim is currently directional folklore among counselors, not a settled empirical fact. Still, the heuristic is sound:

- Polished, generic, thematically coherent prose has always been weak. AI tends to amplify those failure modes.
- Specific, idiosyncratic, slightly-imperfect teenager prose has always been strong.

The leading indicator on AI-mediated evaluation: Caltech's VIVA pilot. Per *LA Times* (Jan 2, 2026), Caltech used InitialView's VIVA AI voice-interview tool on roughly 10% of early applicants in 2025–26 — applicants submitted videos and were questioned about their research projects "akin to a dissertation defense." Ashley Pallie, Dean of Undergraduate Admissions: *"Can you claim this research intellectually? Is there a level of joy around your project? That passion is important to us."* Georgia Tech uses AI to scan transcripts. **By the time Daughter B applies in 2029, AI-mediated screening at top STEM schools is plausibly normal**, which means the relevant skill is the ability to *defend her own work in conversation* — i.e., depth, not polish.

5. Application volume and selectivity

Common App, 2025–2026 cycle (per Common App's January 1 deadline update report, via Forbes Jan 16, 2026): more than **7.6 million** total applications and 1.2 million distinct first-year applicants as of Jan 1, 2026 — up 7% YoY, on track to exceed 8 million by end of cycle. Number of applicants reporting standardized scores rose 11% YoY; non-reporting fell 4%.

Class of 2030 Ivy results (Ivy Day, March 27, 2026): Brown Daily Herald, Columbia Spectator, Yale Daily News reporting and institutional press releases — five Ivies (Harvard, Princeton, Penn, Dartmouth, Cornell) declined to release official numbers.

School	Admit rate (estimated where withheld)	Applications
Columbia	**4.23%**	~57,000+
Yale	**4.24%**	~52,250
Brown	**5.35%**	record
Cornell	~7% est.	~65,000+
Harvard / Princeton / Penn / Dartmouth	withheld; estimated 3.2–5.0%	record
Stanford	~3.7%	record
MIT	~4.2%	record
Caltech	~3.78%	record
Duke	~4.7%	record

Compression is structural, not cyclical. Class sizes at elite schools are essentially fixed (Harvard ~1,650, Stanford ~1,700, MIT ~1,100). Applications keep rising because Common App lets you apply to 25 schools as easily as 8; brand consolidation pulls students to "name schools"; and international demand keeps growing.

Yield protection and the waitlist economy. Schools facing demand uncertainty are deferring and waitlisting aggressively. **A defer or waitlist is now 50–70% of the binary outcome you should expect from a top-10 school**, even with a strong app.

Part II: The Brutal Math

Acceptance rates — Class of 2030 (entering fall 2026)

Tier	Examples	Admit rate
Tier 0 (sub-5%)	Harvard, Stanford, MIT, Princeton, Yale, Caltech, Columbia	3–5%
Tier 1 (5–8%)	Brown, Penn, Duke, Vanderbilt, Northwestern, Rice, Dartmouth	5–7%
Tier 2 (8–13%)	UCLA, Cornell, Johns Hopkins, WashU, USC, Notre Dame, Berkeley	8–13%
Top SLACs	Williams, Amherst, Pomona, Swarthmore, Bowdoin, Harvey Mudd	6–9%

The Early Decision arbitrage: real, but selective and not magic

ED-heavy schools (40–55% of class filled before RD): WashU (~61%), Vanderbilt, Duke, Northwestern, Penn, Brown, Columbia, Rice (40–55%).

Indicative ED vs RD admit rates (Town & Country / counselor data, 2026):

- Brown: ED ~16.5% / RD ~3.9% (≈4×)
- Penn: ED ~14% / RD ~5%
- Cornell: ED ~17% / RD ~6%
- Dartmouth: ED ~17% / RD ~5%
- Columbia: ED ~8% / RD ~2–3%

- Harvard SCEA: ~7% / RD ~2.5%
- Princeton SCEA: ~12% / RD ~3.5%
- Johns Hopkins ED: ~11% / RD ~3%
- MIT EA (non-restrictive, no ED): ~5% (no real ED-style advantage)

Honest caveat: Some of the ED gap is recruited athletes + diversity hooks self-selecting into early. The unhooked ED bump is closer to **1.5–2.0×**, not 3×. **It is still the largest single legal lever an unhooked applicant has.**

ED II (Jan deadlines) is a meaningful second swing — Vanderbilt, NYU, Tufts, Bowdoin, Pomona, Emory, U Chicago. If denied or deferred from ED I, ED II should be active strategy.

ED financial-aid escape clause (corrected from earlier framing): Common App's ED agreement and every Ivy/elite ED policy include an **explicit financial-aid release clause**. An ED admit can withdraw without penalty if the family judges the aid package insufficient. The right pre-ED process is:

1. Run the **net price calculator** at the ED candidate.
2. If NPC indicates the family will likely qualify for aid that makes the school workable, ED is much safer than commonly framed.
3. ED is binding *if* the aid package is workable — not unconditionally.

When NOT to ED: - The applicant is below the school's middle-50 academic threshold (ED becomes a faster rejection plus deferral lock-out). - The applicant has not identified a clear top choice (schools sniff this via "Why X"). - The NPC indicates the financial gap is unbridgeable and you don't want to use the escape clause.

Demonstrated interest: real, but bimodal

Top public/Ivy schools do NOT track DI (Penn discontinued alumni "conversations" entirely starting 2025–26 cycle, per *The Daily Pennsylvanian*, July 2025). For Ivies, DI = applying ED + a precise "Why X" supplement. **Mid-elite privates and SLACs DO track it intensively** — Tufts, BU, Tulane, Northeastern, USC, Vanderbilt, most LACs. Visit + open every email + interview + ED.

Part III: Financial Aid — The Big Story This Note Originally Underweighted

For a middle-/upper-middle-income California family with two daughters, **financial aid is now the dominant variable, not headline admit rates.** The 2024–2026 wave of aid expansion at top privates makes them often *cheaper* than UCs.

Free-tuition / no-loan thresholds at top privates (2024–2026)

School	Free tuition threshold	Notes
Princeton	<$250K	Most generous on the spectrum
MIT	<$200K	Announced 2024
Harvard	<$200K	Free everything <$100K (Mar 2025)
Yale, Penn, Brown	<$200K	
Stanford	<$150K free tuition; aid up to ~$300K	
Notre Dame Pathways	<$150K free; partial to $200K	
Emory Advantage Plus	<$200K	Starting Fall 2026
Tufts Tuition Pact	<$150K	First applies to Class of 2030
Vanderbilt Cornelius Vanderbilt Scholarship	merit, full tuition	

Per Forbes (Mar 27, 2026, on Class of 2030 Ivy Day):

> "Princeton covers full tuition for families earning up to $250,000. Harvard, Yale, MIT, and Penn cover tuition for families earning up to $200,000."

Implication for this family: Run the NPC at every plausible private target under realistic income/asset assumptions. For most middle-income California families, **HYPSM-tier total cost is often lower than UC sticker (~$40K/yr)** once need-based aid is applied. This completely inverts the conventional "private = expensive, public = affordable" intuition.

The federal sibling discount is gone — and you have two daughters

The 2024–25 FAFSA replaced EFC with SAI and **eliminated the multiple-students-in-college adjustment**. Per MEFA (Oct 2024): *"That feature was removed with the 2024-25 FAFSA, and families noticed."* No indication the Department of Education plans to bring it back.

Direct dollar implication for your family: ~2 years of overlap (Daughter B's freshman/sophomore = Daughter A's junior/senior, fall 2030 – spring 2032). For each of those years:

- **Federal aid** does *not* discount for siblings in college.
- **CSS Profile schools** (most elite privates: HYPSM, Penn, Brown, Duke, Northwestern, etc.) **still ask about siblings in college and many quietly compensate via institutional aid.** Per MEFA: *"Colleges understand the plight of families, and many are taking action to minimize the impact of this change on students by keeping their financial aid offers as close as possible to previous years…"*
- **UCs and most state schools** do *not* compensate.

Counterintuitive consequence: An HYPSM-tier ED admit for Daughter A may produce a *lower total family cost over 8 years* than a UC admit, **once Daughter B's overlap years are factored in**, especially if family income is in the $150K–$300K band where elite-private aid bites hardest. **Run NPCs for both daughters at every plausible school under realistic income assumptions before committing to ED.**

Part IV: The Spike (Differentiator at the Top)

> "Colleges in the past few years have been shifting away from preferencing the 'well-rounded jack of all trades' student, more towards students with a 'spike.'… They aren't looking for well-rounded students, rather a well-rounded class."

A spike is: - Sustained 2–4 year focus on one domain - External validation (publication, competition rank, employer/grant/lab letter, working product) - Tangible artifact (paper, code, prototype, performance, organization that exists without you) - A coherent story about the intellectual question the student is chasing

A spike is NOT: - Founding a 501(c)(3) that exists on a website with no real beneficiaries - "President" of three clubs that meet six times a year - A summer program you paid $8,000 to attend - Volunteer work disconnected from genuine academic interest

T-shaped, not pure-pointy. Pure specialization is brittle. The strongest applicants are deep in one vertical with two or three credible adjacencies that reinforce a story.

Important age caveat (this is the part that does NOT apply to Daughter B yet): "Build a spike" is appropriate for 10th–12th grade. For an 8th- or 9th-grader, premature specialization tends to produce one of two failure modes — (1) parent-driven activity that dies the moment the kid develops independent preferences, or (2) genuine narrowing that closes off the breadth needed to find authentic interests. The strongest 12th-grade spikes typically emerge from **9th–10th grade discovery moments**, not from 8th-grade plans. **For Daughter B: breadth now, depth in 10th, spike in 11th, artifact in 12th.**

Research programs: ranked by signal value

1. **RSI, SIMR, SSP, MIT PRIMES, Clark Scholars, PROMYS** — *free, sub-5% acceptance, faculty-run.* Real currency. Acceptance to one is itself a credential. *(Note: an earlier version of this list named "Caltech YESS" — that program does not appear to exist as described and has been removed.)*
2. **Pioneer Academics** — paid (~$6K), accredited via Oberlin/UNC, real peer review. Most defensible of the paid programs.
3. **Lumiere** — paid (~$3–5K), 1:1 PhD mentorship, structured. Mid-tier signal.
4. **Polygence** — paid ($3K+), rolling admission, mentor quality varies. Lowest signal among the major paid programs because the bar to enter is so low.

The cynical truth: Top admissions readers can spot a Polygence-pattern paper at 30 yards. The signal degrades as paid mentorship floods the market. Better plays in 2026:

- **Local university research** (UCSD, Scripps, Salk Institute, UCSD School of Medicine — direct outreach to PIs is still effective for motivated juniors).
- **A real-world product** (an iOS app with users, a widely-used open-source tool, a Kaggle/HuggingFace contribution, a peer-reviewed code repository).
- **Free flagship programs** where acceptance itself is the credential.
- **Self-directed long project** with verifiable artifact and a teacher recommender who can speak to the work specifically.

Activities that still genuinely move the needle

- Top-tier competitions: USAMO, **USACO Platinum** (not just Gold/Silver), **USAPhO Gold**, **USABO Finalist** (top 20, not just Semifinalist), Regeneron STS Scholar, ISEF Finalist, Math Olympiad medals, Concord Review publication
- A founded organization solving a real problem with 100+ users/beneficiaries verifiable by a third party
- Publication in a venue where humans actually read it (not pay-to-publish)
- Sustained employment in a relevant field (research assistant, software engineering intern at a real company)
- National-level juried art/music/dance accomplishment

Part V: California-Specific Levers

Lever #1: Gender at STEM-heavy schools

Per *College Transitions* (using CDS data, approximate; year-over-year noise applies):

> "Caltech: 4.3 [percent admit rate for women] versus 1.8 [for men]. MIT: 6.8 versus 3.5. Harvey Mudd: 21.1 percent for women versus 8.6 percent for men. Carnegie Mellon: 14.7 versus 9.8. Georgia Tech admitted women at a 19.1 percent rate versus 11.6 percent for men in 2024."

Female admit rates at the most selective STEM schools are **~2–2.5× male rates**. The applicant pool is still ~70% male at MIT/Caltech, so this is unlikely to disappear in 2–4 years. Schools won't advertise it; the data confirms it.

Implication: MIT, Caltech, Harvey Mudd, Carnegie Mellon, and Georgia Tech should be *high-priority targets*, not stretch reaches, for a strong female STEM applicant — especially relative to their headline admit rates. **This applies to both daughters.**

Lever #2: Test-blind UCs as the safety floor — but watch this space

The UC system is currently strictly test-blind — they will not look at SAT/ACT scores even if submitted. For a high-GPA California resident, this is a meaningful structural advantage **today**.

> "California residents have a 12.7% acceptance rate, compared to 8.9% for out-of-state students and 5.2% for international students." — UC Berkeley, Class of 2029

Major-selection is everything at UCs: - Berkeley CS in EECS: estimated **3–5%** (a single counselor source claimed ~1.9% — that figure is not corroborated by Berkeley's published CDS data and should be treated as a low-confidence estimate) - Berkeley CS in L&S: ~10–12% - Berkeley undeclared / other Letters & Science: ~15% - UCLA CS in Samueli: ~6% - UCLA L&S undeclared: ~10–12%

Operational rule: If the goal is the school, apply to the less-impacted major and switch internally. If the goal is CS specifically at Berkeley/UCLA, the application bar is *higher than HYPSM*.

Daughter B caveat: UCs have an active Standardized Testing Task Force debating reintroduction. The test-blind floor that holds in 2027 for Daughter A may not hold in 2029 for Daughter B. **Hedge by having her get a strong test score regardless of UC policy at her time.**

Lever #3: PIQs are the entire UC application

UCs don't accept letters of recommendation, are test-blind (today), and don't have teacher narratives. **The four 350-word Personal Insight Questions are everything.**

PIQ rules: - Each of four answers should highlight a *different* dimension (don't repeat across them) - Use specific numbers, dates, names — not abstractions - At least one should clearly tie to the intended major's intellectual core - Avoid the "challenging classes prepared me" cliché - Start writing in August of senior year, draft 6–8 versions, kill the bad ones

AP scores DO count for UCs (UCs see AP/IB scores even though they don't see SAT/ACT). For STEM applicants, strong APs in Calc BC, Physics C, Chem, CS-A serve as semi-quantitative signal in lieu of SAT.

Lever #4: California school context

San Diego County / Bishop area means: Torrey Pines, Canyon Crest, Bishop's School, Cathedral Catholic, Scripps Ranch, La Jolla, Del Norte are well-known to readers. Each high school has a known shape — readers calibrate. Top decile rank at a known feeder is a positive signal; not maxing the school's most rigorous track is a negative. Bishop, CA (Inyo County) is *less-known*. Could be either advantage (geographic diversity) or disadvantage (no track record). Find out which from the school counselor and the high school profile sheet.

Part VI: Daughter A's Playbook (HS Class of 2028)

Daughter A is currently end of 10th grade. She has **~18 months** until the ED I deadline (Nov 1, 2027). The 24-month operational arc applies.

Now (May 2026, end of 10th grade) — months 0–6

- **Junior-year rigor locked.** Calc BC by junior year, AP Physics C and/or Chem, an English AP, at least one major-aligned AP (CS, Stats, Bio). For a STEM applicant, falling short of Calc BC by junior year is a real signal weakness at MIT/Caltech/Stanford.
- **First diagnostic SAT or ACT** by June 2026. Identify which test fits her. ACT favors reading/science fluency; SAT favors math precision and vocabulary. Pick one and don't switch.
- **Identify the spike candidate** (not the spike itself). By August, a one-paragraph thesis: *"I want to spend 18 months going deep on X because Y."*
- **Summer 2026 plan locked.** RSI/SIMR/SSP applications were due January 2026 — that window has closed for summer 2026. Realistic moves now:
  - **Local lab outreach** (UCSD, Scripps, Salk) — cold emails this month for unpaid summer research
  - **Self-directed project** with verifiable artifact by Dec 2026 (paper draft, working software repo, competition prep)
  - **Apply to RSI/SIMR/SSP for summer 2027** (junior summer is the credential-bearing one anyway)
  - Paid program acceptable IF artifact-producing: Pioneer > Lumiere > Polygence

Junior year, fall 2026 (months 6–12)

- **First real SAT/ACT sitting** (Aug or Oct). Target 1500+/34+ before second attempt.
- **AP scores accumulate.** Strong scores (4–5) on May AP exams are now de facto admissions data, especially at Yale (test-flexible) and any school weighing course rigor.
- **Build the artifact.** By December, the spike should produce *something* — paper draft, working software repo, competition placing, research proposal accepted.
- **Counselor relationship.** Counselor decides "most rigorous." They need to know her by name, know her spike, and have at least one substantive conversation per quarter. *(Cross-daughter note: this relationship is multi-year family capital — they'll write Daughter B's letter too.)*
- **Identify two teachers** for recommendations. Junior-year STEM teacher + non-STEM teacher who can speak to intellectual range. *(Cross-daughter note: pick teachers who Daughter B can plausibly NOT use later, to avoid two-similar-letters fatigue.)*

Junior year, spring 2027 (months 12–18)

- **Second SAT/ACT sitting** by April. **Lock the score by June.** Empirical reality: average prep gain is ~10–30 points; ceiling for sustained 100+-hour prep is closer to 100–150 points. Don't budget around "150 guaranteed."
- **Major-aligned summer program** (RSI/SIMR if accepted; otherwise lab work, internship, or Pioneer cohort).
- **First school list** — 4 reach, 4 match, 4 safety, **plus a dedicated ED candidate.**
- **Run NPCs at every ED candidate AND every plausible private target.** This is the gate for ED.
- **Visit the top 4–6 schools** if feasible. ED requires real conviction.
- **Common App opens August 1.** Have draft personal statement complete by August 1.

Senior year, fall 2027 (months 18–24)

- **ED I deadline:** typically Nov 1. Submit one binding ED if and only if (a) it is unambiguously her top choice, (b) the NPC indicates the financial package will be workable (and you've decided whether to invoke the escape clause if it isn't), (c) her stats meet middle-50 of the school's admitted class.
- **EA submissions** to MIT, Caltech, Georgetown, Michigan, Notre Dame as fits. Non-binding; gives information.
- **UC application: Nov 30 deadline.** Hard. Non-extendable. PIQs need 4–6 weeks of drafting.
- **ED II in January** as a strategic second swing if ED I is denied.
- **RD deadlines: Jan 1–Jan 5.** Most.
- **Submit FAFSA early** (opens Oct 1, 2027 for 2028–29 cycle). New SAI rules mean **no sibling discount even though Daughter B will be entering 2 years later**; CSS Profile schools may compensate institutionally.

Waitlist playbook (50–70% likely outcome at top 10)

If waitlisted at a high-priority school: 1. Within 1 week: submit **Letter of Continued Interest** affirming "if admitted I will attend" (only at one top choice). 2. Mid-March: brief update with one substantive new item (Q3 grades, new award, completed project artifact). 3. After that: silence unless invited. Persistent contact reads as desperate.

Part VII: Daughter B's Playbook (HS Class of 2030)

Daughter B is currently end of 8th grade. The original version of this note's 24-month playbook **does not apply to her**, and applying it would actively harm her. Here is what does.

The framing for Daughter B

She has ~42 months until ED I (Nov 2029) and ~46 months until decisions land (Mar 2030). Three things follow from that horizon:

1. **The rule set will shift before she applies.** UCs may reintroduce testing. AI-mediated screening will spread beyond Caltech's pilot. Post-SFFA practices will iterate. Federal Title VI investigations may produce rulings that constrain holistic review or ED. **Don't optimize her plan around the 2026 meta. Build durable transferable foundations instead.**
2. **Premature optimization is the dominant failure mode at her age.** 8th–9th grade spike-building usually produces brittle, parent-driven profiles that collapse at 16. The strongest senior-year applicants almost always emerge from 9th–10th grade *discovery*, not from 7th–8th grade *plans*.
3. **Watch Daughter A's cycle as a free dataset.** A's process — what worked, which essays landed, which schools were realistic, which counselor advice mattered, what the AP/SAT/test-prep cadence actually requires — is the most valuable calibration data B will ever have. Don't waste it.

Now (May 2026, end of 8th grade) — through summer 2027

- **Math acceleration trajectory.** Single highest-leverage middle-school decision. To reach Calc BC by 11th grade (the implicit MIT/Caltech bar), she needs Algebra 1 in 8th grade or Geometry in 9th. If she's on track, hold it. If she's behind, summer-accelerate now. **This decision compounds for 4 years.**
- **Reading volume.** SAT/ACT verbal scores correlate with cumulative reading hours more than with prep. Build the habit at 13–14, not at 16. Target: 30+ books a year, mixed fiction/nonfiction.
- **Sample many domains.** Math team, programming, biology, writing, music, one physical activity. The point is exposure breadth so her eventual spike is *authentic* — not parent-prescribed. Let her quit things.
- **No SAT/ACT prep yet.** Test prep done in 8th–9th grade depreciates by junior year. PSAT 8/9 in 9th grade is the first useful diagnostic.
- **No Polygence/Lumiere yet.** Save the budget for 10th–11th grade when the artifact has time to mature.
- **One unstructured "obsession project."** Whatever she picks (game dev, robotics, fanfiction, a YouTube channel, a small business). The signal is *self-directed sustained effort*, not the topic. Schools eventually distinguish "kid who pursued one thing on her own for 3 years" from "kid who attended programs."

9th grade (fall 2026 – spring 2027) — through summer 2028

- **Lock the math/science track** at the highest level her HS offers. Honors Algebra 2/Trig or Pre-Calc Honors as appropriate.
- **PSAT 8/9** as a no-stakes baseline.
- **Continue breadth.** Resist the urge to "pick a spike." This is still discovery phase.
- **Watch Daughter A's spring 2027 SAT/ACT process.** Note what tutoring helped, what didn't, how A allocated time.

- **Summer 2027:** age-appropriate programs (COSMOS for rising 11th is too early; SSP/RSI/SIMR are summer-after-11th). Local enrichment, math camp (AwesomeMath, Ross/PROMYS at 9th-grade level — Ross is for rising 10th), or self-directed work.

10th grade (fall 2027 – spring 2028) — through summer 2029

This is where Daughter A's playbook starts being relevant for Daughter B too. By this point:

- **Spike candidate identified** by end of 10th grade (one-paragraph thesis).
- **AP coverage on track** — typically AP Calc BC by 11th, AP Physics C and Chem by 11th–12th.
- **Diagnostic SAT or ACT** in spring of 10th. Real testing in 11th.
- **Summer 2029 program target locked** by January 2029 — RSI/SIMR/SSP (free flagship) applications due Jan; backups identified.
- **Daughter A is by now a freshman somewhere.** Calibration data is now extremely high-quality. Use it.

11th–12th grade (2028–2030)

By this point, the strategic landscape will have evolved (see Part VIII), but the **operational structure** will be similar to Daughter A's playbook above — adapted to whatever rules are current. The key difference: Daughter B will have *seen* her sister go through it, so the family's execution should be sharper.

Cross-cutting rules for Daughter B specifically

- **Don't replicate Daughter A.** Different spike, different schools (with overlap permitted only where genuine), different teacher recommenders if attending the same HS.
- **Authenticity is a function of distance from parental optimization.** The further her interests are from "what worked for her sister," the more readable they are as her own.
- **The robust play is interest-driven, not strategy-driven.** A genuine 4-year obsession beats any manufactured pointiness.

Part VIII: What May Shift Before Daughter B's Cycle (2029–30)

Things the current note treats as fixed that probably won't be by 2029:

Variable	Current state (2026)	Plausible 2029 state
UC test policy	Strictly test-blind	Reintroduced as test-considered or test-required; UC Standardized Testing Task Force actively debating
AI-mediated screening	Caltech VIVA pilot, ~10% of early applicants	Normal at top STEM schools; possibly multi-school standard via vendors like InitialView
AI essay detection	Trained-reader pattern matching only	Possible institution-wide tooling; possible shift to in-person/proctored writing samples
SFFA equilibrium	2 cycles of data, volatile	6 cycles of data, stable; race-neutral proxies (zip code, school context, "adversity") matured
ED leverage	~1.5–2× unhooked bump	Possibly constrained by federal antitrust scrutiny (currently active); possibly diminished by yield-protection counter-moves
Federal Title VI posture	Active investigations of holistic review at multiple elites	Possible binding rulings or consent decrees changing what schools may consider
Common App dominance	Dominant; 7.6M+ applications	Some erosion to Scoir, Coalition, and direct applications
Financial aid thresholds	\$200K–\$250K free tuition at HYPSM	Higher thresholds or new dimensions; possible constraints if endowment taxes rise under federal policy
Sibling discount in federal aid	Eliminated	Likely still eliminated; possible institutional patches at CSS Profile schools

Operational implication for Daughter B: Build a profile that is **robust to whichever meta is current in 2029–30**, not optimized for the 2026 meta. Specifically:

- Get a strong test score regardless of UC policy at her time.
- Develop the ability to *speak* about her work (defendable in an AI interview), not just write about it.
- Build a spike with a verifiable real-world artifact, which survives any narrowing of essay-based holistic review.
- Diversify across SCEA/EA/ED I/ED II/RD to hedge ED policy shifts.

Part IX: Family-Portfolio Strategy (Cross-Daughter)

The original version of this note treated each applicant as singular. With two daughters two years apart, several things only make sense at the family level.

A. Coordinate, don't co-target

If both daughters target the same 6–10 schools and same major, you've under-diversified. Concrete coordinations:

- **Different ED targets** unless one school is genuinely both daughters' top choice. The family will gain ground-truth experience from Daughter A's cycle that informs Daughter B's calibration — but only if there's enough variation in the school list to learn from.
- **Complementary spikes** if interests genuinely diverge. "Two STEM daughters from the same household with the same spike" reads to readers as parent-driven. The flavor of the spike (computational bio vs. pure math vs. systems vs. ML applications vs. physical sciences) should be authentic to each.
- **Non-overlapping recommenders** — at the same HS, the same AP Physics teacher will eventually be asked for both. Plan now to give Daughter B *different* teacher relationships than Daughter A, especially the second (non-STEM) recommender.

B. Counselor relationship is shared family capital

Same HS = same counselor. The counselor's perception of "this family" carries between siblings. If Daughter A's process goes well — counselor knows her, advocates for "most rigorous," writes a sharp letter — that builds capital for Daughter B. Cultivate it as a 4-year family-level relationship.

C. Test-prep and tutor economics are 4-year, not 2-year

Serious tutoring dollars invested in Daughter A in 2026–27 cost much less the second time around (same tutor, same materials, accumulated parent expertise). Plan as a multi-year capability build, not two independent expenses.

D. The financial overlap years (fall 2030 – spring 2032)

Two academic years of two-in-college. Federal aid does not discount; CSS Profile schools may. **Modeling implication:**

1. Run NPCs for both daughters at every plausible target under your *current* income/asset assumptions and a *projected* version (factor expected income trajectory).
2. Specifically model **"Daughter A at school X, Daughter B at school Y"** combinations for total 8-year cost — not single-school comparisons.
3. The cheapest 8-year combination is often **two HYPSM-tier schools with full need-based aid** rather than two UCs at full sticker, *if* income is in the $150K–$300K band. This is counterintuitive and worth modeling explicitly.
4. ED for Daughter A at a top need-met private is *not* riskier financially than an unhooked RD path to the same school — and it provides 2 years of stable financial signal before Daughter B applies.

E. Daughter A's outcome is Daughter B's calibration

Whatever happens to Daughter A — admit, defer, waitlist, reject — produces specific lessons for Daughter B. Document them. Specifically track:

- Which essays got which results (insofar as you can tell).
- Which test scores actually mattered at which schools.
- How the counselor's "most rigorous" call was made.
- Which summer programs returned credentialing value vs. which didn't.
- How the ED bet played out financially.
- Which schools' "fit" turned out to be real vs. marketing.

Part X: Honest Tradeoffs and Self-Criticism

What I'm less certain about

1. **Whether the "spike" advice is itself a fad.** Five years ago consensus was "well-rounded." Now it's "pointy." By 2029–30, reader exhaustion with manufactured spikes may push the pendulum back. The robust play is *authentic interest in something*, not manufactured pointiness.
2. **Durability of post-SFFA data.** Two cycles is small. Schools are clearly experimenting with race-neutral proxies. The Class of 2031–2032 data may differ.
3. **AI's trajectory.** By 2027–28, AI essay polish may be undetectable. Schools will likely move further toward verifiable signals — test scores, AP exams, in-person/AI interviews, proctored writing samples. The deep trend is toward unfakeable signals.
4. **UC system stability.** UCs are debating reintroducing testing. If they do, the test-blind floor disappears — particularly relevant for Daughter B.
5. **Federal policy volatility.** The Trump-era Department of Education is actively pressuring elite institutions on admissions. Title VI investigations of holistic review are escalating; ED is under antitrust scrutiny. The legal landscape may shift mid-cycle.

What I'd push back against in my own analysis

- **The "don't game the essay" advice can be over-applied.** Strategy and authenticity aren't opposed. The best essays *are* strategically structured *and* authentically voiced. The mistake is when polish overrides voice.
- **The Asian-American framing risks overgeneralization.** A South Asian female CS applicant from a Bay Area feeder vs. a Korean female biomedical applicant from rural Inyo County are not the same applicant strategically. Profile specificity matters more than ethnicity-as-category.
- **The "ED is leverage" point can mislead.** ED is leverage *only when the applicant is already competitive*. If she's not in the middle-50 academically, ED at a stretch school is just a faster rejection plus a deferral that locks her out of better-targeted ED elsewhere.
- **My ranking of paid research programs may be too cynical on Polygence.** Some Polygence projects are genuinely strong. Signal degradation is real but individual outcome depends on mentor and student.
- **The claim that "AI prose loses now" is folklore, not data.** It's a sound directional heuristic, but there is no published empirical evidence that human readers reliably detect AI prose at scale. Calibrate accordingly.

What this analysis cannot answer

- Specific school-fit decisions (need a real college list discussion, not a generic report).
- Financial-aid trade-offs given specific family income/asset structure (need actual NPC outputs).
- Whether a particular spike is "good enough" — requires looking at her actual work.
- Personality fit (small LAC vs. mid-size research university vs. large public is a temperament question, not an analytics question).

Part XI: Sources

Primary institutional sources (verbatim quotes drawn from)

- Harvard Gazette — "Harvard announces return to required testing" — Hopi Hoekstra, April 11, 2024
- Supreme Court slip opinion 20-1199 — *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard*, Roberts majority, June 29, 2023
- California Governor's Office — AB 1780
- MIT News — Stu Schmill on Class of 2028
- Penn Admissions — 2025–26 changes
- The Daily Pennsylvanian — Penn ends alumni conversations (July 18, 2025)
- Common Application — Deadline Update 2025-12-11 PDF

Cycle data and analyses

- Forbes — Common App report shows rise for 2026 (Jan 16, 2026)
- Forbes — Class of 2030 admissions rates (Mar 27, 2026)
- Town & Country — Ivy League acceptance results 2026
- Oriel Admissions — Ivy Day 2026 Results
- Brookings — Complex Ramifications of SFFA v. Harvard
- Harvard Crimson — How the Supreme Court Shaped Class of 2028
- Harvard Magazine — Admissions After Affirmative Action

AI in admissions

- LA Times — AI may be scoring your college admissions essay (Jan 2, 2026)
- GradPilot — AI Policies for 170+ Universities
- College Essay Advisors — AI use in Top 30 admissions offices

Demographic and gender data

- College Transitions — The Widening Gender Gap
- Nature Scientific Reports — Disparate Impacts on Asian American Applicants
- NBER Working Paper 27068 — Asian American Discrimination in Harvard Admissions
- UCLA Law Review — Obscuring Asian Penalty (West-Faulcon, 2019) — methodological critique of Espenshade's 140-point figure

Financial aid

- MEFA — Making sense of the sibling discount loss (Oct 2024)
- Understanding FAFSA — Strategies to protect your sibling discount
- College Raptor — Sibling Discount going away
- Financial Aid Services — The New FAFSA: 9 Big Changes 2026

Strategy and trend

- Oriel Admissions — Top 25 admissions stats Class of 2030
- Oriel Admissions — Return of Standardized Testing 2026–2027
- Crimson Education — Early Decision Acceptance Rates Class of 2030

- North Star Admissions — 2025/2026 Trends

UC system and California

- Dewey Smart — Expert UC Application Strategy 2026
- Oriel Admissions — UC Berkeley Acceptance Rate Class of 2030
- NBC News — California bans legacy admissions

Research programs

- Canonical free flagship programs: RSI (Research Science Institute, MIT), SIMR (Stanford Institutes of Medicine Research), SSP (Summer Science Program), MIT PRIMES, Clark Scholars (TTU), PROMYS (BU), Ross (OSU), Telluride (TASP/TASS)

- Pioneer Academics
- Polygence
- Lumiere — Complete Guide

Legal landscape

- Stanford Law — SFFA v. Harvard FAQ
- Harvard Law Review — The Harvard Plan That Failed Asian Americans

Revision Log

- **2026-05-03 (initial)**: First version. Treated the two daughters as a single ~24-month cohort.
- **2026-05-03 (revision)**: Major correction.
  - **Cohort framing fixed**: Daughter A (HS '28) and Daughter B (HS '30) are 2 years apart, not adjacent. Split into two playbooks (Parts VI and VII).
  - **Added Part III (Financial Aid)**: HYPSM-tier free-tuition expansion + federal sibling-discount elimination + CSS Profile institutional offsets. Single biggest omission in v1.
  - **Added Part VIII (What May Shift)**: forecast for Daughter B's 2029–30 cycle.
  - **Added Part IX (Family-Portfolio Strategy)**: cross-daughter coordination, financial overlap modeling, shared counselor capital.
  - **Fixed factual issues**: Common App "8M" → "7.6M+ as of Jan 2026, on track to exceed 8M"; removed unverified "Caltech YESS"; flagged Berkeley CS "1.9%" as low-confidence; added Espenshade methodological caveat (1997 data, author-acknowledged inflation); softened test-prep "150 points" claim; corrected ED "sight-unseen" framing to acknowledge financial-aid escape clause; calibrated "AI prose loses" claim from assertion to directional heuristic.
  - **Added Caltech VIVA / InitialView** specifics from LA Times Jan 2, 2026.
  - **Added Penn alumni-conversations termination** with direct DP citation.
  - **Tightened sourcing**: primary sources (CDS, school newsrooms, Common App PDFs) prioritized over counselor-blog aggregators where possible.

Next critical update: October 2026, when Class of 2030 freshman demographic and academic data lands and Class of 2031 applicants begin submission. Re-evaluate testing requirement landscape, ED acceptance rate compression, SFFA-cycle-3 demographic data, and any UC testing-policy announcements (most relevant to Daughter B).